

Community, Leisure, Arts, Heritage and Culture Strategic Policy Committee Hybrid Meeting 12/03/2025

A meeting of the Community, Leisure, Arts, Heritage and Culture Strategic Policy Committee (CLAHC SPC) was held on Wednesday, 12th March 2025 at 3pm in the Council Chamber Dooradoyle and Online via Microsoft Teams.

MEMBERS PRESENT:

CHAIRPERSON:

Cllr. Fergus Kilcoyne
Cllr. Azad Talukder
Cllr. Brigid Teefy
Cllr. Catherine Slattery
Cllr. Dan McSweeney
Cllr. Daniel Butler
Cllr. Gregory Conway
Cllr. John Sheahan
Cllr. Olivia O'Sullivan
Cllr. P.J. Carey
Cllr. Pádraigh Reale
Cllr. Sarah Beasley
Cllr. Shane Hickey O'Mara
Cllr. Tommy Hartigan
Mr. John Ward
Ms. Marion Hurley
Mr. Pete Moles
Mr. Randal Hodkinson

APOLOGIES:

Cllr. Martin Ryan

IN ATTENDANCE:

Mr. Stephane Duclot, Director of Service
Mr. Joe Delaney, Director of Service
Mr. Damien Brady, City & County Librarian
Mr. Seamus O'Connor, Chief Officer LCDRC
Ms. Anne Rizzo, Senior Executive Officer
Ms. Karen Burke, Town Centre First Officer
Ms. Eileen Coleman, Senior Executive Officer
Ms. Fiona McCormack, Senior Executive Officer
Mr. Mike Maguire, Executive Librarian
Ms. Olivia O'Brien, Healthy Ireland, Limerick Coordinator
Ms. Gráinne Mc Mahon, Senior Executive Architect
Ms. Noreen O'Neill, Senior Executive Librarian
Ms. Eileen Gleeson, Staff Officer
Ms. Joanna O'Donoghue, Staff Officer
Ms. Aisling Coughlan, Clerical Officer

Item 1: Introductions/ Role and Responsibilities of SPC

This was the first meeting for the Community, Leisure, Arts, Heritage and Culture Strategic Policy Committee.

The Chairperson Cllr Fergus Kilcoyne welcomed the members and officials and invited all to introduce themselves. A round of introductions took place.

Director of Service Stephane Duclot gave a presentation regarding the roles and responsibilities of Strategic Policy Committee (SPC).

The members were advised that SPC is set up to last for the lifetime of the elected council and that one third of the membership should be from sector relevant to the committee works. Currently CLAHC SPC consist 16 elected members and 6 sectoral representatives, however four vacancies are to be filled by PPN election, bringing that number to 10. Quorum to hold the meeting is formed by minimum one quarter of the approved membership plus one.

The SPC Scheme for 2024-2029 was adopted in November 2024. In accordance with guidelines meetings should be held at least four times a year and calendar of the meetings should be agreed. SPC should have annual work program that should be linked to local authority plans and should consider climate as a cross-cutting issue in their work programmes.

SPC Chair should hold office for a minimum of three years which could be renewed by the Council. Decisions are typically made by consensus, but voting can occur if necessary and the chairperson has a casting vote in the event of a tie.

The Council is and remains the decision-making Authority and it is the task of the SPCs, as committees of the Council, to advise and assist the Council in the formulation, development and review of policy. The remit of the SPCs is to deal only with policy matters and as such they are strategic in nature and have no remit in relation to routine operational matters regarding the delivery of services. The SPC system is intended to give Councillors and relevant Sectoral Interests an opportunity for full involvement in the policy making process from the early stages.

By invitation from S. Duclot each section under Community, Leisure, Arts, Heritage and Culture SPC remit gave a brief overview of their work.

Seamus O'Connor, Chief Officer LCDC welcomed all members and outline main areas of **Community Development** section including:

- Management of Local Community Development Committee (LCDC).
- Responsibility for community elements of the Local Economic and Community Plan.
- Community Engagement, including advice, funding applications support, signposting to appropriate funding opportunities or responsible council officials.
- Managing key community funding programs:



- EU LEADER -program for rural development where the LCDC is the decision-making body. Current budget is almost €7m. Working closely with local development companies especially West Limerick Resources who are Council partner in this programme.
- SICAP (Social Inclusion and Community Activation Programme) - five-year social inclusion program with a budget of €20m. Supports people in disadvantaged areas, focusing on education, job activation, and employment support.
- Community Recognition Fund- acknowledges communities supporting new arrivals from Ukraine and other countries with budget of €1.3m.
- Community Grant Programs- small-scale grants for community projects, repairs and operational funding. Budget this year is €370,000.
- Managing insurance for community playgrounds.
- Bin waiver system- almost 4,000 people in Limerick benefit from this scheme. Limerick is the only Local Authority in the Country providing it.
- Pride of Place- all Ireland competition entered by LCCC every year and hosted by Limerick in 2025.
- Integration - Managing integration for migrant communities and new arrivals, including Ukrainians, beneficiaries of temporary protection and refugees.
- Health & Wellbeing- including Healthy Limerick and Sláintecare initiatives funded by department of Health.
- Age Friendly/ Comhairle na nÓg
- Team Limerick Clean-up (TLC)- 20,000 volunteers participate every Good Friday to clean our streets from rubbish.

Karen Burke, Town Centre First Officer presented work of **Rural Development** team including:

- Town Centre First Plan preparation for Abbeyfeale and Rathkeale. Working with Town Teams in Abbeyfeale, Rathkeale, Newcastle West, Kilmallock and Askeaton.
- Administration of all rural funding programmes, including:
 - Rural Regeneration and Development Funding (RRDF)- open call out for projects is closing on Friday.
 - Town and Village Renewal Funding- expecting a funding call.
 - Outdoor Recreation and Infrastructure Funding- open call out closing on 28th March.
 - CLÁR- Relates to areas of depopulation, call expected later this year.
- Preparation of the Outdoor Recreation Strategy for Limerick.
- Ongoing engagement with rural communities/stakeholders to identify projects, which will support rural communities. Working closely with community development team.

Fiona McCormack, A/SEO, presented main areas of focus for **Regeneration Sports and Recreation Directorate**:

- Responsible for sports facilities across the city and county.
- Working with elected members, clubs, and committees to enhance facilities.

- Limerick Sports Partnership is under their directorate, delivering programs promoting women in sport, working with people with disabilities, and senior groups.
- Provides support to external bodies, national governing bodies, and clubs for greater participation and enhanced facilities.

Damien Brady, City & County Librarian informed members of main activities in areas under his supervision including **Libraries, Arts, Museums & Gallery of Art**.

Four main events highlighted taking place this year in **Library** section:

- Deliver 2025 National Famine Commemoration event with participation of President and broadcasted on live TV on 17th May in Kilmallock.
- Advanced plans for Adare Library in advance of the Ryder Cup.
- Upgrade Dromcollogher Memorial Library in preparation for the 100th anniversary of the fire tragedy on this site in 1926. Event to take place on 5th September 2026.
- Roll out the Skills for Life Programme which is a key action in the National Library Strategy.

Arts:

- Deliver the Arts Council Framework Agreement Programme.
- Deliver the Creative Ireland, Creative Communities Programme, Focus on communities and community art.
- Develop and deliver on the One Per Cent for Arts Scheme, where percentage of capital projects can be spent on arts.

Limerick Museum and Gallery of Art:

- Deliver 40th anniversary programme for Limerick City Gallery of Art in Perry Square, exiting program with series of lectures starting tomorrow.
- Advance plans for accreditation for the Museums Standards Programme of Ireland (MSPI) for Limerick Museum and Limerick City Gallery of Art to enable borrowing of exhibits from national and international galleries.

Eileen Coleman, SEO, Festivals & Events and Tourism informed members of work in **Festivals & Events** team:

- Festival and Event Strategic Planning- Responsible for the implementation of the festival events strategy adopted by the previous Council.
- Delivery of St Patrick's Festival, International Band Championship, Riverfest-winner of Chamber Ireland Festival of the year, Halloween in Limerick and Christmas in Limerick.
- Administration of Festivals and Events Grant scheme.
- Collaboration with Shannon Conference and Sports Bureau and UL on attracting events to Limerick.

Gráinne Mc Mahon, Senior Executive Architect explained role of **Public Realm and Heritage** section.



Heritage Team consists of 3 sections: Conservation, Heritage and Archaeology.

- Conservation Team - planning S.57's exemptions, emergency work, grant funding, and planning referrals.
- Heritage Team - Heritage grants and implementation of the Heritage Plan.
- Archaeology - archaeology-related planning referrals and items such as ministerial consents.

Cllr D. McSweeney thanked the presenters and acknowledge work being done by each of the section. He is looking forward to work on the policies.

Item 2: World Health Organisation – Healthy Cities Application- for Consideration for recommendation to the Full Council

A presentation was made by Olivia O'Brien, Healthy Limerick Co-ordinator, giving the members overview and context of WHO Healthy Cities Application.

The members were advised that The Healthy Cities Network, initiated by the WHO in 1987, emphasises the critical role of local governments in health and sustainable development. The programme has grown to include National Networks in 20 countries within the WHO European Region, connecting over 1,800 cities, counties, and towns.

The approach seeks to put health high on the political and social agenda of cities and to build a strong movement for community led, evidence based health and wellbeing at the local government level. It strongly emphasizes equity, participatory governance and solidarity, intersectoral collaboration and action to address the determinants of health. Successful implementation of this approach requires innovative action addressing all aspects of health and living conditions. The approach recognises the determinants of health (where people live, grow, play, learn, and work) and the need to work in collaboration across public, private, voluntary and community sector organisations. This way of working and thinking includes involving local people in decision-making, requires political commitment and organizational and community development, and recognises the process to be as important as the outcomes.

The Lead for the European Healthy Cities Network visited Limerick last September. Afterwards an official request (EOI) was submitted to the WHO, and Limerick was invited to apply for WHO accreditation. Drafted application was sent to members in advance of this meeting. It is hoped that Community, Leisure, Arts, Heritage and Culture SPC will recommend the application for consideration to Full Council on March 31st. If approved application will be submitted to the Irish National Healthy Cities and Counties Network meeting on April 1st for onward submission to the WHO.

Joining the network will provide broader opportunities for collaboration and visibility internationally. It will also provide international recognition as a healthy city, making Limerick a more attractive place to live and visit. Limerick's vision is to become a healthier, more equitable, and sustainable city and county by addressing health

inequalities, enhancing community participation, and designing spaces that promote well-being. There is also a chance to look at bringing some European funding into Limerick.

This agenda item was proposed by Cllr O. O'Sullivan, seconded by Cllr A. Talukder that the World Health Organisation – Healthy Cities Application go to the Full Council for consideration.

Cllr P. Reale congratulated on the progress and acknowledged his full support for this initiative.

Item 3: New Local Studies Website - Update

A Presentation was given by Mike Maguire, Executive Librarian to the members updating them on the new Local Studies Website launched in October 2024.

<https://limericklocalstudies.ie/>

The website contributes towards the achievement of the Council mission statement to “provide ambitious leadership and strive to deliver an innovative, vibrant, safe and inclusive Limerick for everyone” and its stretches well beyond the boundaries of Limerick. The main reason for creation of the site it to enable sharing of digital collections with the public.

The previous site, established in the early 2000s was outdated and due to its technical limitation could not be developed further. The aim was to create new site that would have intuitive navigation, responsive design, engaging content and work well on any screen size. Site that would reflect reach content and provide easy navigation, reflecting the rich tapestry and content of the local studies collection. Dual purpose of the site makes content sharing accessible for casual users interested in local studies and local history but also researchers who appreciate access to primary material and massive quantity of data.

Site proves to be popular not only in Ireland but also with diaspora nations with obituaries being one of the most visited pages. User engagement statistics show how important it was to make site friendly to access from other devices showing 49% users accessing from mobile/ tablet.

Vast collection of materials can be found on the site including:

- Decade of Centenaries -council publications, exhibitions, journals, films recordings etc.
- Articles- aims to connect into the heritage history community and become a hub of that community also invites submission of articles.



- Family History -general guides and specific family histories including Noel Murphy Family History.
- Obituaries, death notices, etc. 1781-1951- searchable database and original clippings from newspapers.
- Trades & Street Directories, 1769 - 1976- searchable database and original publications.
- Maps - including 1907 'Sale of Limerick. Vast collection of the maps with that users can view samples online and arrange to see originals.
- The Séamus Ó Ceallaigh GAA Collection - includes approximately 500 issues of various journals, books, and annuals also Great Limerick Sportsmen biographical profiles and club files.
- Collections including books, journals, music and newspapers.

There are many more areas of the website that are fascinating going back in time and some to be still developed.

The Chair expressed his thanks for the comprehensive presentation.

Ms. M. Hurley asked what work is done to get this information to communities, schools, and historical societies.

Presenter advised that there was media coverage at the time of the launch and ongoing efforts include using social media, occasional newspaper coverage and news page on the site itself. He acknowledged the need to improve self-promotion and identified engagement with schools as important area to develop further.

Cllr. Shane Hickey O'Mara expressed his thanks and advised he would have loved to have this resource as a student as it is great this is now available.

Item 4: Local Sports Plan- Update

A presentation was made by Fiona McCormack, SEO, Regeneration, Sport and Recreation giving the members overview of Local Sports Plan.

The National Sports Policy requires the development of Local Sports Plans by the local authorities which will reflect the vision and objectives of this National Sports Policy. The intention is to review needs and set out actions to increase participation in sport and physical activity across the city and county. The plan will be developed in conjunction with the Limerick Sports Partnership (LSP), sports clubs, communities, and other partners and will be underpinned by national and local policies and plans.

The main goal of the Plan will be to improve participation in sport and physical activity, increase collaboration with sporting bodies and to assist key stakeholders, including the Council and the Limerick Sports Partnership to leverage funding in the future for enhanced sport and physical activities. In 2023, adult participation levels in sports was 43%, and the objective is to get it to greater than 60% by 2027.

The initial phase was the launch of Get Ireland Active, an interactive database mapping geographical areas for physical activity. Consultations were established through the City and County Managers Association (CCMA). Four local authorities were selected for the pilot: Carlow, Cavan, Clare, and Laois and national steering group was established, comprising members from Sport Ireland, the Department of Sport, and all four local authorities.

Funding has been received from Sport Ireland to procure a consultant. The request for tender is out, and assessment is expected by the end of March. Following the consultant's appointment, engagement with stakeholders will begin using My Point platform but also with residents, community groups, and national governing bodies. The process includes facilitated workshops to put consultation findings where key actions and visions are set out. There will be development of a strategic framework where focused interviews will be conducted to refine the emerging draft. A final strategic framework will be developed, with a draft for consideration at the July SPC for consideration for recommendation to full council. The aim is to have approval from the full council and launch the plan in October 2025.

Item 5: Date of next meeting

The Chairperson Cllr Fergus Kilcoyne thanked all for the presentations made. The next meeting of the Community, Leisure, Arts, Heritage and Culture SPC will take place on Wednesday 14th May 2025 in Council Chamber, Dooradoyle at 3pm and online. Dates of the future meetings will be circulated to members.

Minutes Proposed By: _____

Minutes Seconded By: _____

Minutes Signed By Chair: Fergus Kilcoyne Date: 14/5/2025